03-20 第1篇

阅读理解（说明文） Why Chillies Taste Hot

① Walk through any market in Sichuan or Hunan, and a river of red chillies is waiting for your eyes. Some people love that burning feeling on the tongue; others cry, cough, and wave their hands. An interesting question hides behind this small red fruit: **why does a chilli feel hot, while an apple or a grape does not?**

② The secret is a natural chemical called **capsaicin**. It is colourless, has no smell, and mostly hides in the white inner wall of the chilli — not in the seeds, as many people think. When you bite the chilli, capsaicin meets the nerves on your tongue. Our body has a special nerve ending called **TRPV1**. Its normal job is to warn us about real heat — like touching a hot pot or a flame. But capsaicin is shaped just like "heat" to this nerve. So even though the chilli is cool, the brain still shouts, "Fire! Fire!" Your face turns red, you sweat, and your heart beats faster. This is the "hot" taste — in fact, it is not a taste at all, but a **safe trick**.

③ So, is this trick harmful? For most people, the answer is **no**. A little chilli even helps: it pushes the stomach to **move faster**, it keeps food safer on hot summer days, and some studies in Shandong and Chengdu show that people who enjoy mild spicy food often feel more energetic in cold weather. However, "a little" is the important word. Too much capsaicin may hurt the stomach wall, and some people with sensitive stomachs feel pain or have a bad sleep after a very spicy meal.

④ What if your mouth really burns? Many students rush to drink cold water — but that is **not helpful**. Capsaicin does not melt in water. It melts in **fat** and in **alcohol**. So a spoonful of yoghurt, a piece of cheese, or warm milk works much better than a whole glass of iced cola. In the end, the "fire" slowly goes away, and the tongue returns to normal, a little tired but safe.

⑤ The chilli, then, is a clever little fruit. It looks dangerous, it tricks our nerves, yet it also brings colour to dishes and warmth to our hands on a cold day. Like many things in life, its heat is not really heat — it is a language the plant uses to say, "Look at me." And millions of Chinese cooks have listened to that call for hundreds of years.

根据文章内容，选择最佳答案。

1. What does the writer mainly want to explain?

A. Where the best chillies in China are grown.
B. Why chilli tastes hot and what happens in our body.

C. How to cook Sichuan dishes at home.
D. Why different people have different tastes.

2. Where does most of the capsaicin in a chilli hide?

A. In the seeds.
B. In the green top.
C. In the white inner wall.
D. In the red outer skin.

3. Why does our brain shout "Fire!" when we eat a chilli?

A. The chilli is actually very hot in temperature.
B. Capsaicin looks like real heat to the TRPV1 nerve.
C. The tongue is burned by the chilli's red colour.
D. The stomach sends a fire signal upwards.

4. According to the article, which statement is true?

A. Chilli is always dangerous for every person.
B. Cold water is the fastest way to cool the burning feeling.
C. A little chilli can help the stomach move and bring warmth.
D. Capsaicin has a strong smell and a bright colour.

5. What is the best way to cool a burning mouth after spicy food?

A. Drink a big glass of iced cola quickly.
B. Eat yoghurt, cheese, or drink warm milk.
C. Rinse the mouth with more chilli sauce.
D. Sit quietly and do nothing at all.

答案与解析

1.
【答案】B
【题型】主旨大意题
【定位】第①段末句提出问题；② — ④段围绕辣椒为何辣及身体反应
【解析】文章核心为"辣椒为何辣及身体反应"。A、C、D 非主旨。故选 B。

2.
【答案】C
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第②段 "mostly hides in the white inner wall of the chilli — not in the seeds"
【解析】主要藏在白色内壁。A 与原文明确否定；B、D 无依据。故选 C。

3.
【答案】B
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第②段 "capsaicin is shaped just like 'heat' to this nerve... brain still shouts, 'Fire!'"
【解析】辣椒素形状与真实热量在神经上的信号类似。A、C、D 与科学解释不符。故选 B。

4.
【答案】C
【题型】判断正误题
【定位】第③段 "pushes the stomach to move faster... more energetic in cold weather"
【解析】少量辣椒有益。A、B、D 与原文矛盾。故选 C。

5.
【答案】B
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第④段 "melts in fat and in alcohol. So a spoonful of yoghurt, cheese, or warm milk works much better"
【解析】辣椒素溶于脂肪，应食奶制品。A 错误；C、D 无依据。故选 B。

词汇注释（超纲词）

- **chilli** [n.] 辣椒
- **capsaicin** [n.] 辣椒素
- **nerve** [n.] 神经